

Babylon

How to Live When America Stops Being Christian

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LIVEWELL BY JAMES BELL

Build houses and live in them. Plant gardens and eat their produce... But seek the welfare of the city where I have sent you into exile, and pray to the Lord on its behalf, for in its welfare you will find your welfare.

— Jeremiah 29:5, 7

Introduction: The Part of the Letter We Never Read

There is a verse from the prophet Jeremiah that you have seen on a coffee mug, a graduation card, a wall hanging in a Christian bookstore. For I know the plans I have for you, declares the Lord, plans for welfare and not for evil, to give you a future and a hope. We have made it the most personal verse in the Bible, a private promise that things are going to work out for me, and we did it by tearing it loose from the four verses that come before it, which almost no one reads, and which were written to people whose whole world had just ended.

In 597 before Christ the army of Babylon took the first wave of Jerusalem's people a thousand miles east into captivity, and a decade later they came back and burned the temple to the ground. To the exiles already in Babylon, sitting in the wreckage of everything that had told them who they were, the prophet Jeremiah sent a letter. The plans verse is the eleventh line of that letter. The first lines are not a comfort. They are a set of instructions, and they are the most surprising instructions in the Old Testament, because they tell a defeated and homesick people not to do the two things every defeated and homesick people want to do.

I have argued the diagnosis at length in another book, so I will not relitigate it here. The short version is the one most of the American church still cannot bring itself to accept. The long arrangement we call Christendom, in which the culture assumed the faith and carried it for free, is over, and it is not coming back,

and what died with it was never Christianity but only Christianity's cultural scaffolding. We are exiles now. We are a minority in a place that no longer shares our memory. That is the diagnosis, and a diagnosis, once you have it, is strangely useless. It tells you what happened. It does not tell you how to live on Tuesday.

The letter does. And it does not stop at you are in exile. If it did, it would be a death certificate. It keeps going, into the imperative mood, into verbs. Build. Plant. Marry. Multiply. Seek. Pray. Six commands to people who expected to be told either to fight their way home or to lie down and disappear. God told them to do neither. He told them to live, fully and fruitfully and on purpose, in the one place they were sure no real life could be lived. He told them to make Babylon bloom.

This book is those verbs. It is not another diagnosis of how bad things are, because you have had enough of those and so have I. It is the part of the letter we never read, worked patiently into an ordinary life, into your work and your house and your marriage and your children and your street and your prayers. It is an attempt to answer the only question that finally matters once the grief has had its say. Not how do we get our country back, and not how do we make peace with losing it, but the older and harder question the exiles were handed first. How do we live, and live well, here.

The whole letter turns on a single word, and it is the word this whole platform takes its name from. Seek the welfare of the city, God says, and in its welfare you will find your welfare. The Hebrew word under welfare is shalom, and shalom does not mean what we have shrunk it to. It is not the absence of conflict or the calm of a private heart. It is wholeness, flourishing, the way things are supposed to be, a city where the hungry are fed

and the stranger is safe and the work is good and the weak are not crushed. God tells the exiles to seek that, for Babylon, the empire that burned their temple. And He tells them that their own flourishing is hidden inside it. You will not find your shalom by guarding it. You will find it by spending it on the good of a city that is not your home.

That is what it means to live well in exile. Not to wait out the captivity with your bags packed. Not to forget you are a captive and melt into the crowd. To build, and plant, and bless, and stay strange, in a place you did not choose, for the sake of a God the place does not know. The exile is not the interruption of the good life. For the people of God it has nearly always been the address where the good life is learned.

So let me hand you the verbs, one at a time.

Build Houses

The first thing God tells the exiles to do is the most ordinary thing imaginable, and that is exactly its power. Build houses and live in them. Not tents. Not anything you can strike and carry when the call to march home finally comes. Houses, with foundations, the kind of thing a man builds when he has decided he is staying. To a people straining toward the horizon for the first sign of rescue, God says the one thing they did not want to hear. Stay. You live here now. Build something you cannot take with you.

There are two ways to hold a place you did not choose, and the instruction to build houses kills them both. The first is the suitcase. The suitcase Christian keeps his bags by the door. He is only passing through, he reminds you, this world is not his home, and he means it as piety but it functions as an excuse. Why invest in a city you are leaving. Why pour yourself into the schools or the streets or the long civic work of a place that is under judgment anyway. The suitcase looks spiritual and is really just a refusal to love what God has told you to love. The second way is the bunker. The bunker Christian also knows he does not belong, but his answer is to wall himself in, to build a parallel everything, to pull his family and his money and his attention back behind the fortifications and wait for the barbarians to lose interest. The suitcase will not invest in Babylon. The bunker will not touch it. God forbids them both with four words. Build houses and live in them.

A built house is a confession. It says I am staying, I am exposed, I have decided that this particular patch of a pagan empire is

worth the labor of permanence. And permanence, it turns out, is the precondition of every good thing the rest of the letter asks for. You cannot seek the welfare of a city you are about to abandon. You cannot love a neighbor you have walled out. Wendell Berry has spent a lifetime making this single point against an American economy built to move us, that there are two kinds of people, the ones he calls boomers, who treat every place as a resource to use up and leave, and the ones he calls stickers, who settle, who stay, who learn a place well enough to love it and tend it across a lifetime. The exiles are commanded to become stickers in Babylon. You cannot love a place in general. You can only love it in particular, this street, these neighbors, this work, this long unglamorous staying.

And staying means working, because a house has to be paid for, and the exiles took their place in the ordinary economy of Babylon. They did not retreat into a holy enclave funded by nostalgia. They learned trades, kept books, built things, served a pagan city's needs and were paid for it, and in doing so they discovered what the church keeps having to rediscover, that there is no such thing as secular work for a person who belongs to God. The Reformers recovered this and gave it a name. Vocation. The conviction that the milkmaid at her pail and the magistrate at his bench serve God as truly as the priest at his altar, that God is not waiting for you in the religious corner of your life but is already present in the work of your hands, the spreadsheet, the classroom, the loading dock, the exam room. Tim Keller spent a book arguing that the gospel transforms how and why and for whom we work, that the Christian in Babylon does not clock in to fund the real Christian life that happens on Sunday but offers the work itself, done with excellence and integrity, as a way of seeking the city's good. Your cubicle is one of the houses Jeremiah told you to build.

A built house is a bet on staying. And almost nothing the gospel asks of you is possible until you have made that bet, because you cannot bless a place you are standing on with one foot out the door.

But notice the second half of the command, because we are prone to hear only the first. Build houses, and live in them. Not just build. Live. A house is not a worksite, it is a place you are meant to inhabit, to rest in, to be a human being and not a machine in. The exile who builds and builds and never lives has not actually obeyed, he has only relocated his striving. This is why the people of God have always carried Sabbath into exile with them, the weekly refusal to work that declares with the whole body that the world is held by God and not by my effort. Abraham Joshua Heschel called the Sabbath a palace in time, a sanctuary you build not out of stone but out of hours, and he understood that a people can be enslaved in a free land if they never stop, and free in a hostile one if they know how to rest. To live in the house you have built, to actually dwell there and not merely maintain it, is its own quiet resistance to a Babylon that measures you by your output and would gladly consume every hour you have. Build the house. Then have the nerve to live in it.

Plant Gardens

The second command is slower than the first, and the slowness is the point. Plant gardens and eat their produce. A house you can throw up in a season. A garden makes you wait. You put a seed in the ground and you do not eat for months, and if you plant the slow things, the fruit tree, the vine, you do not eat for years, and some of what you plant you will never taste at all. To tell a homesick exile to plant a garden is to tell him the truth he has been refusing. You are going to be here long enough for trees to bear. Stop counting the days until rescue. Start counting the seasons until harvest.

There was a competing prophet in Babylon named Hananiah, and he told the people exactly what they wanted to hear. Two years, he said. Within two years God will break the yoke of Babylon and bring you all home and the furniture will be where you left it. Jeremiah called him a liar to his face and gave the people the number no one selling hope ever wants to say out loud. Seventy years. A lifetime. Most of you will die here. Your grandchildren will see Jerusalem, not you. And in the same breath that he took away the fantasy of a quick return, God told them to plant gardens, because the two go together. The lie that the exile will be short and the refusal to plant a garden are the same refusal. The truth that the exile will be long and the willingness to plant are the same willingness. The false prophet promises you next spring in your old country. The true prophet hands you a shovel and points at the Babylonian dirt.

This is the discipline the American church has almost entirely lost, and Eugene Peterson named it in a title borrowed from, of

all people, Nietzsche. A long obedience in the same direction. Peterson wrote that book against what he called an instant society, a culture of immediacy that has trained us to want everything now and to abandon anything that does not pay off fast, and he argued that discipleship is constitutionally the opposite of that, a slow walk in one direction over a whole life. We do not believe this. We are a people of the launch and the campaign and the metric that has to move this quarter. We want revival by Friday and a Christian nation by the next election and our own sanctification on a schedule we can post about. And a garden does not care about any of it. A garden answers only to seasons and patience and the slow fidelity of someone who keeps coming back to water ground that shows nothing for a long time.

To plant a garden in Babylon is to make peace with not seeing the harvest, and this is perhaps the hardest thing the letter asks. The whole impulse to take the country back by force is, underneath its anger, a refusal of the seventy years, a demand to be the generation that wins, to see the fruit in our own lifetime and our own headlines. But the faithful have always planted what they would not harvest. The monks who copied Scripture by hand through the long centuries after Rome fell did not live to see the civilization their patience would seed. They copied in the dark because it was true and because it was theirs to do, and the harvest came for someone else, four hundred years later, who never knew their names. That is gardening. You are planting an orchard for grandchildren you will not meet, in a country that is not yours, and the willingness to do that without bitterness is most of what it means to live well in exile.

The false prophet promises you a short exile so you will not have to plant anything. The true prophet tells you it will be long, and hands you seed. Faithfulness is what

*you put in the ground when you have stopped expecting
rescue by spring.*

So plant the garden. Take the slow job and stay in it. Pour your life into the child and the church and the neighborhood whose payoff is decades out and may never be visible to you at all. Resist the tyranny of the fast result that has made the church frantic and shallow and perpetually disappointed. The exile is long. That is not the bad news. The bad news would be a faith that could only survive a short one. A garden is the proof that you have believed the hard true word about how long you will be here, and have decided to make the dirt bear fruit anyway.

Take Wives and Raise Children

The third command is the most defiant, though it does not look like defiance. Take wives and have sons and daughters, the letter says, take wives for your sons and give your daughters in marriage, that they may bear sons and daughters. Multiply there, and do not decrease. To a people convinced their story was over, God commands the most ordinary and most hopeful act a human being can perform. Marry. Have children. Raise them to marry and have children of their own. Do not let the line thin out and die in Babylon. The exile is not a reason to stop the future. It is the place the future will now be made.

Understand what this meant in a captive, demoralized people. Decline is the natural posture of the defeated. Why bring children into a lost cause, why give your daughter in marriage to face the same exile, why multiply when the whole trajectory is down. And God cuts straight across that despair. Multiply, and do not decrease. The home, He is saying, is not a private comfort you retreat into while the real history happens elsewhere. The home is the real history. It is the first and most durable outpost of the people of God in a foreign land, the place where the faith is either carried into the next generation or quietly dropped, and no political victory and no cultural strategy will matter at all if the households fail.

The whole architecture of how God's people survive comes back to this. Long before there was a temple to lose, there was the command in Deuteronomy to a family at a table. These words shall be on your heart, and you shall teach them diligently to your children, and talk of them when you sit in your house and

when you walk by the way and when you lie down and when you rise. The faith was always meant to be transmitted at close range, parent to child, in the texture of ordinary domestic life, and in exile that transmission becomes everything, because the culture will no longer do any of it for you. In Christendom the home could be lazy about formation, because the school and the town and the very air carried the faith alongside you. In Babylon the air carries something else. Your children are being catechized all day long, by the screen, by the school, by the feed, by a thousand small liturgies of a city that worships other gods, and the only question is whether anything at your own table is strong enough to compete. The family that does not actively form its children in exile is not staying neutral. It is handing them to Babylon by default.

This is why marriage itself has to be recovered as a covenant and not a contract, and I have written elsewhere about that whole battle, so here I will only connect it to the letter. A culture organized around the self treats marriage as a deal that lasts as long as it serves me, and a deal cannot bear the weight of forming a child or witnessing to a city, because a deal is provisional and a child needs something that will not quit. The exiles were told to build their marriages and their children into Babylon as a permanent presence, and permanence is exactly what the surrounding culture can no longer imagine. A marriage that actually keeps its vows, in plain sight, across decades, is one of the loudest sermons a Christian household can preach in an age of the disposable. The watching neighbor does not know he is being preached to. He only knows that something across the street has lasted, and he cannot account for it, and the not being able to account for it is the whole point.

Your children are being formed by something every

hour of every day. The only choice you have is whether the strongest formation in their life happens at your table or somewhere else. In exile there is no neutral.

I am a father, and I will not pretend I do not feel the undertow of all this, the pressure to outsource the formation of my own children to people and screens better funded and more relentless than I am. Every Christian parent in this country feels it. The letter does not offer us a strategy for winning that fight at the level of the culture. It offers us something more modest and more powerful, which is the command to make our own homes the first place the kingdom is visible, to multiply and not decrease, to raise children who know in their bones a different story than the one Babylon is telling them, and to send them out as the next generation of exiles who can build and plant and seek and bless. That is not retreat into the family. It is the family as the seedbed of everything else. Babylon is downstream of ten thousand kitchen tables, and so is the church that will outlast it.

Seek the Welfare of the City

Now we come to the line the whole letter has been building toward, and it is the line that should stop a defeated people cold. Seek the welfare of the city where I have sent you into exile, and pray to the Lord on its behalf, for in its welfare you will find your welfare. Not your own welfare. The city's. The shalom of Babylon, the empire that razed Jerusalem and dragged you here in chains. Seek its flourishing. Work for its good. Want it to thrive. This is not what you say to a conquered people. It is the opposite of what every conquered people has ever wanted to hear, and it is the center of gravity of the entire Christian life in exile.

We have to feel how scandalous it is before we can obey it. The natural posture toward Babylon is one of two things, and we have met them both already in different clothes. Either you want Babylon to fall, you nurse its coming judgment, you would not lift a finger to help the city that humiliated you. Or you want into Babylon, you envy it, you would trade your strange identity for a comfortable seat at its table. God forbids both and commands a third thing that neither the resentful nor the assimilated can imagine. Pour yourself out for the good of the city. Make it more just, more whole, more flourishing, more shalom, precisely as a people who belong entirely to Someone else. James Davison Hunter gave this posture a name a generation ago that has stuck because it is right. Faithful presence. Not defensiveness against the culture, not desperate relevance to it, not pure withdrawal from it, but faithful presence within it, the slow patient committed labor for the good of the actual place, done by people

whose hope is anchored somewhere the place cannot reach.

And shalom is bigger than we let it be, so let me say what seeking the welfare of the city actually looks like with your hands. It is not a vague civic niceness. The shalom God commands is the wholeness of the whole place, which means it has a particular shape and a particular bias. The Scriptures are relentless and specific about what the flourishing of a city requires, and it is always the same short list that the powerful would rather not hear. The poor are fed and not crushed. The stranger and the immigrant are protected and not exploited. The widow and the orphan, the people with no one to advocate for them, are defended. The scales are honest and the wages are paid and the vulnerable are not ground up to enrich the strong. To seek the shalom of your city is to seek that, on your street and in your systems, for the people Babylon counts as nothing. It is not a partisan program and it cannot be captured by a party, because both parties will happily take the parts of that list they like and bury the rest. The exile takes the whole list, because the whole list is what shalom means.

This is the pattern that made the early church incomprehensible to the empire that hunted it, and it is worth remembering because it is the same instruction, obeyed. When the great plagues swept the Roman cities and the pagans, sensibly, fled and left the sick to die, the Christians stayed and nursed them, their own and their neighbors, at lethal cost to themselves, because they served a Lord who had touched lepers and because a dying stranger was, to them, a neighbor whose welfare they were bound to seek. They gathered the infants the city left exposed on the hillsides to die. They sat slave and master at one table. They had no power to change a single Roman law and they changed the Roman world anyway, from underneath, by relentlessly seeking the welfare of

a city that despised them. Robert Putnam has documented at exhausting length how thoroughly our own society has come apart at exactly this seam, how the bonds of neighbor to neighbor have frayed until we bowl alone and grow old alone and die among strangers. Into that fraying, Jeremiah's letter drops a command that has never been more concrete. Be the neighbor Babylon forgot how to be. Seek its welfare. Its loneliness is part of what you are sent to heal.

God did not tell the exiles to seek their own welfare and let Babylon fend for itself. He told them to seek Babylon's welfare, and promised that their own was hidden inside it. The church that only ever sought its own good has been looking for its life in the one place the letter says it is not.

Here is the quiet indictment in all of this, and it is ours to carry. The American church, by and large, has not been seeking the welfare of the city. It has been seeking its own welfare, its power, its market share, its comfort, its protection, and it has often treated the actual city, with its actual poor and actual strangers and actual lonely, as either a threat to be feared or a mission field to be harvested, but rarely as a neighbor whose flourishing we are simply commanded to want. And we wonder why our witness rings hollow. We have been disobeying the central line of the letter while quoting the verse three lines down about the plans God has for us. The promise and the command are bound together, and you cannot have the one while ignoring the other. Seek the city's welfare. Your own is in there, where you stopped looking.

Pray for the City

The command to seek the city's welfare does not end with our hands. It ends on our knees. Seek the welfare of the city, and pray to the Lord on its behalf. God tells the exiles to pray for Babylon, and this small addition does something the activism could never do on its own, because it goes to work not only on the city but on the one who prays. You can seek a city's welfare for a while out of grim duty, with resentment still simmering underneath. You cannot pray for a city, day after day, year after year, and go on hating it. Prayer for Babylon is how God dismantles the exile's bitterness from the inside.

Think about what He is asking. Pray for the prosperity of the regime that burned the temple. Ask God to bless the city that took your freedom. There is no harder prayer in the Old Testament, and there is none more clarifying, because it forces the exile to settle the deepest question of all. Is Babylon my enemy to be cursed, or my assignment to be blessed. The whole letter has already answered. Babylon is not the enemy. It is the city God Himself has sent you into, on purpose, for a reason, and the proof that you have understood that is whether you can pray for its good and mean it. The prophets cursed Babylon's evil and they were right to, and at the very same time the exiles were told to pray for Babylon's welfare, and both are true, because to seek a city's shalom is precisely to pray against everything in it that destroys shalom while praying for the city itself to flourish. You can want a place to be saved and want its injustices to end in the same breath. That is what intercession is.

This is where the inner life and the public life finally meet, and it

is why I will not let anyone treat prayer as the passive alternative to action. Prayer for the city is the most active thing the exile does, because it is the practice that forms him into someone capable of all the rest. You cannot build, plant, marry, and seek the welfare of a place you secretly despise, not for a lifetime, not without the resentment poisoning everything you touch. The daily discipline of lifting Babylon before God, by name, with its needs and its rulers and its lost and its poor, slowly turns the captive into a citizen of heaven who genuinely loves the earthly city he has been planted in. James K. A. Smith has argued that we are formed less by what we think than by what we practice, that our loves are trained by repeated habit, by liturgies that aim our hearts before our minds catch up. Praying for the city is exactly such a liturgy. Do it long enough and you will find, to your own surprise, that you have come to love Babylon, which is the miracle the command was designed to produce.

You cannot go on hating a city you pray for every day. That is not a side effect of the command. That is the command working, turning a captive into someone who can love the place he was sent.

And the promise still stands underneath it all. In its welfare you will find your welfare. Your prayer for Babylon is not a selfless act of spiritual heroism that costs you everything and returns nothing. God has bound your flourishing to the city's, so that when you pray for Babylon you are, in the deepest sense, praying for yourself and your children and the whole fragile life you are building there. The exile who learns to pray for his city has stopped living as a victim of his circumstances and started living as a priest in the middle of them, standing between God and a place that does not know it is being prayed for, asking the only One who can give it shalom to give it generously. That is

not a holding pattern until the real life resumes. That is the real life. That is a man living well.

Do Not Bow

Everything the letter has commanded so far has been a movement toward Babylon. Build into it. Plant in it. Raise families in it. Seek its welfare. Pray for its good. And every one of those movements carries the same danger, the danger that in drawing so near to the city we will be absorbed by it, that seeking Babylon's welfare will slide imperceptibly into becoming a Babylonian, that the salt will dissolve into the very thing it was sent to season. So the letter needs a guardrail, and Scripture gives it a face. His name is Daniel, and he is the master class in the one thing this whole book has been circling. How to seek a city's good without bowing to its gods.

Watch what Daniel does, because it is both of the things we keep trying to pull apart. He serves Babylon with such excellence that pagan king after pagan king promotes him, trusts him, leans on him, a Hebrew exile running the administration of the empire that destroyed his nation. He is not in the bunker. He is not keeping his bags packed. He has built houses and sought the welfare of the city about as far as a man can. And then the law commands that everyone bow to the king's image, or pray only to the king, and Daniel does the thing that defines him. He keeps praying toward Jerusalem with his windows open. Not hidden, not in armed revolt, just faithful in plain sight, three times a day, with the shades up, and he takes the lions' den as the price without flinching. His three friends say it even more plainly when the furnace is roaring. Our God is able to deliver us, and even if He does not, we will not serve your gods or worship the image you have set up. Serve the city, yes, brilliantly, to the hilt.

Bow to it, never, not if it costs us everything.

That is the line, and it is the line the American church has been catastrophically bad at holding, because we keep getting it exactly backwards. We bow to Babylon's gods while refusing to seek Babylon's welfare. We will fight the city, resent it, fear it, try to seize power over it, and meanwhile we have quietly bent the knee to its actual idols, to the nation, to the market, to the self, to the outrage and the comfort and the consumer appetite that the surrounding culture worships, until our Christianity is barely distinguishable from Babylonian religion with a cross on top. We got it backwards. Daniel sought the city and would not bow. We bow, and will not seek. And the result is a church that is at once too worldly to be distinct and too hostile to be a blessing, which is the worst of both exiles.

To not bow, you have to know which of your assumptions are God's and which are Babylon's, and this is harder than it sounds, because the gods of an age are mostly invisible to the people who worship them. They do not feel like idolatry. They feel like common sense. The most important work of discernment the exile does is learning to see the lenses he has been handed, the political, consumer, individualist, national assumptions that he absorbed without ever choosing them and mistook for the faith itself. This is why theological depth is not a luxury for the exile but a survival skill. A shallow faith cannot tell the difference between Christ and Babylon dressed up as Christ, and so it bows without ever knowing it has bowed. Only a faith that has gone down to the root, that knows the Scriptures and the creeds and the long memory of the church, can stand in Babylon and say with Daniel, I will serve your city and I will not worship your gods, and know exactly where the one ends and the other begins.

The American church keeps getting Daniel backwards. He sought the city and refused to bow. We bow to the city's gods and refuse to seek its good. Faithfulness is the other way around, both halves at once, and neither without the other.

This is what keeps the seeking from becoming surrender, and it is what keeps the distinctness from becoming the bunker. Daniel is the proof that you do not have to choose between loving Babylon and belonging wholly to God, that a single life can do both, can pour itself out for a pagan city's welfare and pray toward the true city with the windows open, for a lifetime, and end old and honored and entirely uncompromised. That is the figure we are called to be. Not the culture warrior who fights the city and bows to its idols. Not the assimilated believer who blesses the city by becoming indistinguishable from it. The exile who seeks the welfare of the city with everything he has, and will not, for anything, bow.

Coda: In Its Welfare, Your Welfare

We started with a verse on a coffee mug, and it is time to give it back its teeth. For I know the plans I have for you, declares the Lord, plans for welfare and not for evil, to give you a future and a hope. We have read that as a private promise of personal good times, and in doing so we have missed the single most important word in it, because that word welfare is the same word, shalom, that appears three verses earlier in the command to seek the welfare of the city. It is not a coincidence and it is not a coffee mug. The shalom God plans to give you in verse eleven is bound, by the deliberate repetition of one Hebrew word, to the shalom He commands you to seek for the city in verse seven. Your welfare and the city's welfare are the same welfare. He said so twice, with the same word, on purpose.

This is the whole letter, and the whole of this book, in one sentence. The plans God has for your good are not a promise that He will lift you out of Babylon into a private prosperity of your own. They are a promise that as you seek the good of the city He has planted you in, you will find your own good waiting there, hidden inside the welfare of the place you were sent to bless. You will not find your shalom by hoarding it behind walls, or by waiting out the exile with your bags packed, or by melting into Babylon until you have no self left to flourish. You will find it the way the letter said you would, by building and planting and marrying and raising and seeking and praying and refusing to bow, by spending your life on the welfare of a city that is not your home, until the day you discover that in seeking its life you were given your own.

So this is what it means to live well, and it is why the platform this book belongs to carries that name. To live well is not to escape the exile. It is not to end it early by force or to make peace with it by surrender. To live well is to seek the welfare of the city where God has sent you, because in its welfare you will find your welfare. It is the six verbs of an ordinary exile life. Build the house and live in it. Plant the garden you may not harvest. Marry, and raise children who know a better story. Seek the flourishing of the poor and the stranger on your street. Pray for the city until you love it. And keep your windows open toward the true city, and do not bow. That is not a strategy for surviving until the good life resumes somewhere else. That is the good life. It always was.

I will not end by promising you that the exile is nearly over, because Jeremiah did not, and the false prophets are the ones who always say it will be short. The number is still seventy years. It is still a lifetime. You and I will very likely die in Babylon, with the gardens we planted bearing fruit for people we will never meet. But the God who wrote the letter did not send His people into exile and then withdraw to wait for them at the border. He went with them, into Babylon, into the furnace, into the den, into the long captivity, and He is with His exiles still, in the houses and the gardens and the marriages and the prayers, in the slow unglamorous labor for the welfare of a city that does not know His name. The exile is not where the good life is suspended. For the people of God it has nearly always been where the good life is finally learned, stripped of the scaffolding, down to the Rock, with nothing left to stand on but Him. Build your house. Plant your garden. Seek the welfare of the city. And live, all the way, well.